Stammtisch

The regulars' table for your neighborhood: pink tables at local cafés and an app that turn first hellos into second meetings.



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THE COURSE

Human-Centered Design and Innovation (HCDIx)

MSxMBA, Columbia University · Fall 2026, Subterm A. Taught by Harry West, Professor of Professional Practice in Industrial Engineering and Operations Research at Columbia Engineering and former CEO of frog.

Say hi once. See them again.

A pink table at your local café signals you're open to chat. An app helps verified neighbors meet there every week. Names stay private until both agree.

THE PROBLEM · CROWDED, BUT ALONE

~1 in 2
Manhattan households is a single person

26%
of Americans know all or most neighbors

~50 h
together to become casual friends

OUR INSIGHT

People aren't missing. Second meetings are.



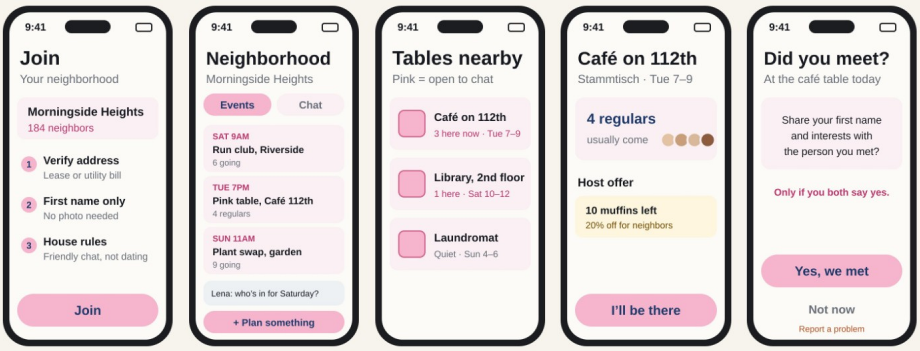
HOW IT WORKS · ONE MECHANISM PER BARRIER

Signal · the pink table
Sitting there means "open to chat". Saying hi is no longer a risk.

Repetition · regular times
Same table, same slot each week, plus events like a run club.

Consent · "We met"
First names only. Details unlock when both tap "We met".

1. Verify address, join the circle
2. Go to a neighborhood event
3. Sit at the pink table
4. Both tap "We met"
5. Same faces every week
6. A neighborhood that feels like home



WHO GAINS

Neighbors · friends nearby, no cold approach

Cafés · regulars in quiet hours

Community spaces · reach new residents

WHO PAYS

Buildings · replace the WhatsApp group

Local businesses · hyperlocal ads in a radius they choose

SAFE BY DESIGN Verified neighbors · public, staffed places · details shared only if both agree · "friendly chat, not dating" · report and block

TARGET USERS & KEY STAKEHOLDERS

Newcomers who want familiar faces, and the local places that want regulars.



PRIMARY USERS

New Yorkers aged 22–35 still building a local circle, newcomers most of all

Surrounded by people all day, known by almost no one. Open to meeting neighbors, but saying hi to a stranger feels risky and a second meeting rarely follows. **Also:** long-time residents who would like to know the people on their block.

Nearly one in two Manhattan households is a single person (Klinenberg, 2012).



Neighbors

GIVE · opt in, verify their address, show up

GET · friends nearby without approaching strangers; low commitment, easy if shy



Local businesses

GIVE · cafés and laundromats host a pink table and a regular time slot

GET · regulars in quiet hours, and a way to reach neighbors with offers



Community spaces & groups

GIVE · libraries, gardens, run clubs and associations host tables and events

GET · more neighbors taking part, and a steady way to reach new residents

PAYING CUSTOMERS Two hypotheses, still to be tested

Buildings & property managers

Today, the building WhatsApp group fills up with complaints, nagging and arguments. Stammtisch replaces it with one app: a dedicated channel for maintenance issues and complaints, kept apart from a positive space where neighbors connect.

Local businesses

Hyperlocal ads and offers that reach only verified residents nearby. Each business chooses its radius, from one block to the whole neighborhood.

INSIGHTS INTO USERS & STAKEHOLDERS

People aren't missing. Second meetings are.

WHY INTERNATIONAL HOUSE IS OUR MODEL

Two of us, Robert and Rebecca, live at International House New York. We see every day how shared dinners and hallway chats with the same people turn strangers into friends. A nine-month study of I-House residents points the same way:

3.97 → 4.54
identification with the I-House community (1–7 scale); informal moments like dining-room chats linked to stronger ties

40% → 65%
of residents donated money in the past month, start vs. end of the year

93%
helped a stranger in the past month, which would rank first among 119 countries

Sternisko, Reinero, Packer & Van Bavel (2025), *Building Global Citizens: A Longitudinal Study of the I-House Experience*. 456 residents from 81 countries, surveyed Aug 2024 and May 2025. The authors call it suggestive, not definitive, causal evidence.

26% of Americans know all or most of their neighbors, down from 31% in 2018 (Pew Research Center, 2025)

~50 h together to become casual friends, 200+ hours for close ones (Hall, 2018)

IN-DEPTH INTERVIEWS · NEW YORKERS AGED 22–35, FROM RECENT ARRIVALS TO PEOPLE WHO HAVE LIVED ALONE IN THE CITY

Same faces, no names

Neighbors, baristas, gym regulars: never past a nod.

"I feel like people deem knowing each other as a responsibility."

Fabian, 25

First meetings, rarely second ones

Events and apps create one-offs that rarely repeat.

"I would like something that curates my events so that I see the same people again naturally."

Jacob, 28

"Too busy" covers fear of rejection

Every follow-up is a bid that can be turned down. If the second meeting simply happens, nobody has to ask.

"You never know whether they missed your message or just don't wanna talk to you."

Robert, 24

STAKEHOLDER INSIGHT · HOSTS

Cafés and laundromats have quiet hours to fill. Regulars are what make a café a "third place": they set its mood and make newcomers feel welcome. (Oldenburg, *The Great Good Place*, 1989)

Next: test this with café owners in Morningside Heights.

CUSTOMER FEEDBACK · 5 TESTERS, AGES 21–28

"I like the physical aspect." Nahdia, 27	→ pink tables in real cafés
"Less strings attached; easy for a shy person." Nazeefa, 23	→ drop in, leave anytime
"With a group, it feels safer." Harry, 28	→ verified neighbors; see who usually comes
Wanted a way to hide personal info Blake, 28	→ first names until both tap "We met"

THE PROBLEM WE ARE SOLVING

In a city of millions, almost every encounter is a one-off.



How we got here: our brief was "Overcrowded New York". We traced how crowding turns into loneliness:

Density → **Anonymity** → **Loneliness**

You meet too many people for any of them to matter. ~75,000 people live on each square mile of Manhattan (US Census, 2020), yet only 26% of Americans know all or most of their neighbors (Pew, 2025).



Same building, different floors. Never met.

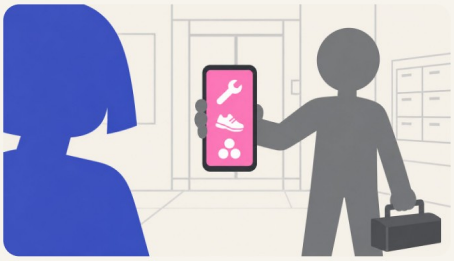
WHY IT PERSISTS

1. Saying hi to a stranger feels risky. Nothing signals who is open to it.
2. When a hello happens, nothing brings the same people back.
3. Asking for a second meeting is a bid that can be turned down, so people say they are "too busy".

FOR	TODAY	THEY NEED TO
New Yorkers aged 22–35 still building a local circle, newcomers most of all	Surrounded by people all day, yet nearly every encounter is a one-off	Turn people they meet once into people they see again, without having to ask

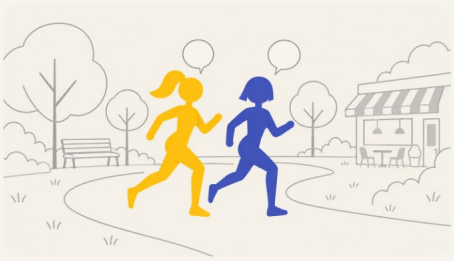
IDEAL EXPERIENCE OF OUR USERS & STAKEHOLDERS

Rebecca's first month in Morningside Heights



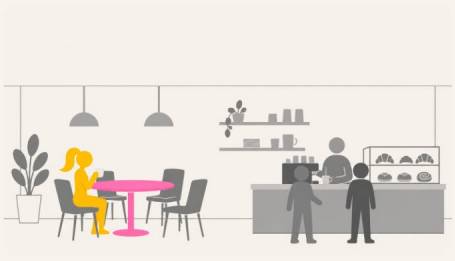
1 Join

She verifies her address and joins her neighborhood circle. Free, first name only.



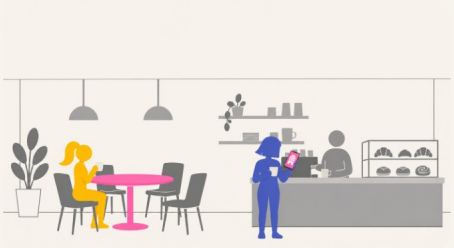
2 Join the run club

On the events board she finds Saturday's run club and goes along.



3 Drop by the pink table

On Tuesday she sits at the café's pink table. Everyone there is open to chat.



4 Share info

She and Jennifer both tap "We met", so names and interests unlock.



5 Make friends

Same table on Tuesdays, same run on Saturdays. The faces become friends.



6 Find her community

Pink tables at the café, library and laundromat: her neighborhood now feels like hers.

FIRST HELLO · steps 1–3: events and the pink table make saying hi normal

SECOND MEETING · steps 4–5: "We met" and regular times bring her back

COMMUNITY · step 6: familiar faces at local businesses and third spaces

FOR THE CAFÉ HOST

A quiet Tuesday afternoon fills with neighbors who come back every week and buy a coffee. The table runs itself; the host only sets the time and an offer.

FOR COMMUNITY SPACES

The library's plant swap and the garden's workday reach new residents without flyers, and the same people keep coming.

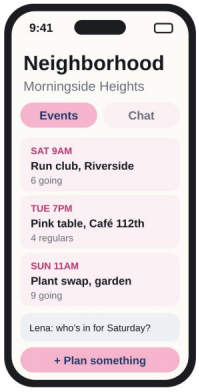
HOW THE SOLUTION WORKS

One neighborhood community, two ways to connect

YOUR NEIGHBORHOOD CIRCLE

Verified neighbors who opted in to meet each other. Like International House or a dorm, but for ordinary apartment buildings and neighborhoods.

ONLINE · THE APP



Chat · ask, borrow, plan; replaces building WhatsApp groups

Events · run club, plant swap, the Tuesday table

Live · see who's at a pink table right now

"We met" · names unlock only when both agree

Building channel · complaints and repairs kept apart from neighbor chat

⟷ plan online, meet in person

IN PERSON · PINK TABLES



Hosts · cafés, libraries, laundromats

Open to chat · sit down to say hi; leave anytime

Regular times · the same faces come back each week

THREE MECHANISMS, ONE FOR EACH BARRIER

Signal

Sitting at the pink table means "I'm open to chat". Saying hi is no longer a risk.

Repetition

Each table has a regular time slot, so the same people come back without anyone asking.

Consent

First names only until both tap "We met". No yes, no sharing.

SAFE BY DESIGN Verified neighbors (lease or utility bill) · tables only in public, staffed places · "friendly chat, not dating" on every table · details shared only if both agree · report and block in one tap

THE ECOSYSTEM OUR SOLUTION WORKS IN

The neighborhood is the platform.



Neighbors
verify, chat, RSVP, show up

Local businesses
cafés, laundromats: host a pink table, post offers, buy hyperlocal ads

Stammtisch
neighborhood circle, verification, table schedule, "We met"

Community spaces & groups
libraries, gardens, run clubs, associations: host tables and events

Buildings & property managers
replace the WhatsApp group, bring every new tenant into the circle

WHAT FLOWS WHERE

Neighbors → hosts	visits in quiet hours, weekly coffee, word of mouth
Hosts → neighbors	a public, staffed place to meet, plus a small offer for regulars
Community spaces → circle	events that give neighbors a second reason to meet
Money → Stammtisch	buildings pay to replace their group chat; local businesses pay for hyperlocal ads within a radius they choose (hypotheses, not yet tested)

COMPARISON TO ALTERNATIVES

Everyone designs the first meeting. Nobody designs the second.

	Meets in person	Same people again	Verified neighbors	"Open to chat" signal	Private until both agree	Regulars for local business
Stammtisch	●	●	●	●	●	●
Timeleft dinners with strangers	●	○	○	○	◐	◐
Bumble BFF friend-matching app	◐	○	○	○	○	○
Meetup interest-group events	●	◐	○	○	○	◐
Nextdoor neighborhood network	○	○	●	○	○	◐
Building WhatsApp group what most buildings use	○	○	◐	○	○	○
Flamingo resident app for buildings	◐	○	●	○	○	○
"Happy to Chat" benches UK park benches	●	○	○	●	●	○

● yes ◐ partly ○ no Our assessment from each product's public description.

Apps stop at the first meeting

Timeleft and Bumble BFF bring new strangers every time. Nothing brings the same faces back.

Neighbor networks stay online

Nextdoor, building chats and resident apps know who lives nearby, but never put people at the same table. Testers called Flamingo "a regular event app".

Signals have no second step

"Happy to Chat" benches make hello easy, but nothing turns a hello into a regular meeting.

ELEVATOR PITCH

Stammtisch in 100 words

100 / 100 WORDS

New York is packed with people, yet many newcomers feel alone. Saying hi to a stranger feels risky, and even when it happens, there's rarely a second meeting.

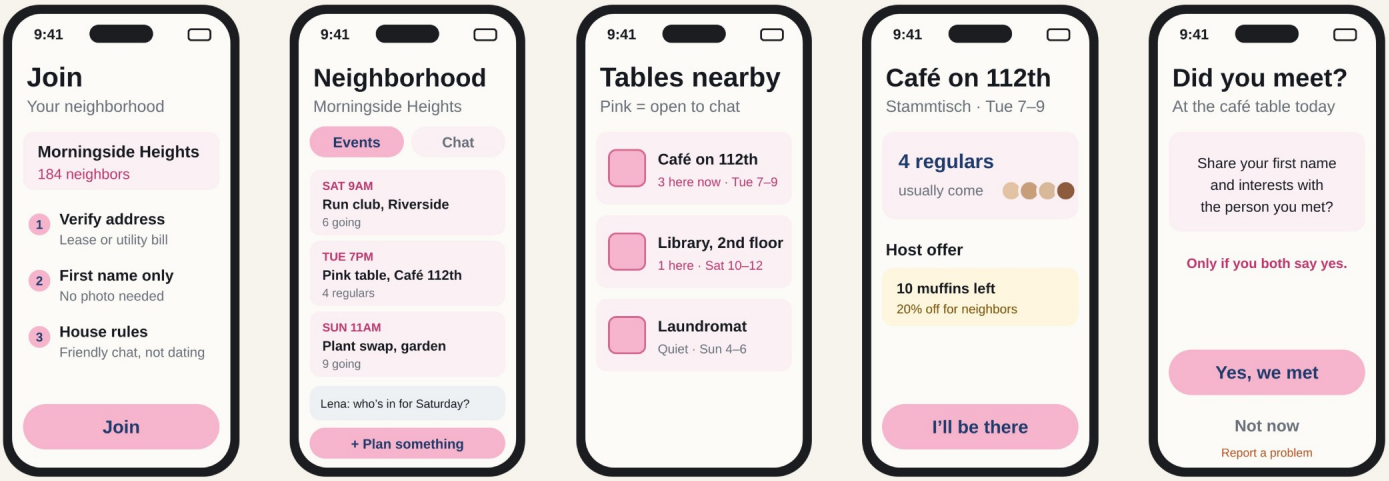
But communities like International House show that when socializing is the norm and residents keep crossing paths in shared spaces, hellos become friendships.

Stammtisch, inspired by the German regulars' table, brings that to every neighborhood: a pink table at your local café signals you're open to chat, and the app helps verified neighbors meet there frequently. Personal details stay private until you both consent, so friendships grow safely, and businesses gain regulars.



PROTOTYPE

Five screens, from joining to staying in touch



1 Join

Verify your address. Only your first name is shown.

2 Neighborhood

Chat and see what's on: run club, plant swap, the Tuesday table.

3 Find a table

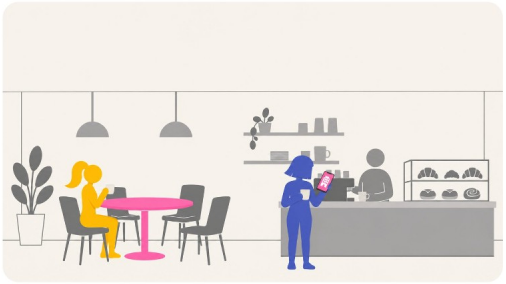
Which pink tables have people right now, and their regular times.

4 Show up

See who usually comes, tap "I'll be there", get the host's offer.

5 "We met?"

You both choose whether to share names. No yes, no sharing.



VIDEO PROTOTYPE

A short film about two newcomers who move into the same building, never meet, and finally connect at the pink table.

1:17 min · watch at szsz.org/rkportfolio/stammtisch

Edited by Robert in Final Cut Pro. Scenes and voices are AI-generated with DaVinci AI.

SHOWN TO

Our class and residents of International House. Feedback was positive throughout.

"I would sit at that table." — Claudia, 27

NEXT: REFINEMENT & TECHNOLOGY

Table check-in · a QR code or NFC tag on each pink table, so "who's here now" is accurate

Host dashboard · businesses set times and offers and see attendance in quiet hours

Smarter table times · suggest slots when most neighbors in the circle are free

Easier verification · through partner buildings and universities, not only documents